

WEST

EDITION 2026–27

INFO BOOKLET

For *Founders & Executives*

A team of capable students on a problem your company cannot get to. No cost, no equity, about an hour a week.

WEST VENTURES · AFFILIATED WITH AUSTIN CHRISTIAN UNIVERSITY

GOWEST.VENTURES

Cover: Emanuel Leutze, Westward the Course of Empire Takes Its Way, 1861 (study).

A LETTER

From the managing partners

Thank you for asking about West Ventures. This booklet is written for founders, owners and executives.

The offer is simple. Bring a problem or an opportunity your company has not had time for. The studio assigns a team of capable students and an experienced project advisor, writes a scope with you in the first week, and delivers against it over a term. It costs you nothing. You keep all equity and intellectual property. We ask for about an hour a week of your time and honest feedback.

When a project turns up an opportunity worth building as its own company, the studio can build it with you as a joint venture. That is optional and separate.

Everything in these pages is how the studio operates today. Where a detail is still being set, it says so. If something here does not answer your question, reply to the email this booklet came in and one of us will answer it.

Jake Oswald

MANAGING PARTNER

Lars Ostervold

MANAGING PARTNER

FOR FOUNDERS & EXECUTIVES

Contents

01	The studio	4
02	The model	5
03	How a project works	6
04	The team	7
05	Expectations	8
06	The work	9
07	Terms	10
08	Outcomes for founders	11
09	From founders	12
10	Student stories	13
11	Joint ventures	17
12	The network	18
13	Leadership	19
14	Questions	20
15	Next steps	21

This booklet is written for founders and executives. Four companion booklets cover the program for parents, students, high schools and universities.

01 · THE STUDIO

What West Ventures is

A venture studio affiliated with Austin Christian University.

West Ventures finds young people with exceptional ability, puts them to work for proven founders and operators, and builds companies with them. It does three things, and each one feeds the others.

I

Teams

Small teams of high school and college students work on real problems for founders and operators, for academic credit. Companies pay nothing.

II

Companies

When a project turns up an opportunity worth building, the studio builds it with the operator who found it, as a joint venture.

III

Network

Partner high schools and universities send their best students. Founders, operators and investors bring the work.

23

Companies served by student teams so far

78

Students who have worked on a team

500

Partner schools planned by 2030

02 · THE MODEL

Kings and *cupbearers*



GUSTAVE DORÉ, NEHEMIAH VIEWS THE RUINS OF JERUSALEM'S WALLS, 1866. NEHEMIAH WAS CUPBEARER TO THE KING.

The thesis is not tied to an industry. The studio's advantage is its model: free work, done by a large group of the country's most capable young people, for the most experienced founders and operators.

The old words for the arrangement are kings and cupbearers. Kings are proven owners and operators with more opportunities than time. Cupbearers are capable young people who need real work and someone to learn from. The studio's job is to match them, at scale.

The arrangement works because each side gets what it lacks. Founders get capable help, at no cost, on work they have no time for. Students get real work, someone to learn from and academic credit. And when a project turns up an opportunity worth building, the studio builds it with the operator who found it, as a joint venture. It expects to start about six companies a year this way.

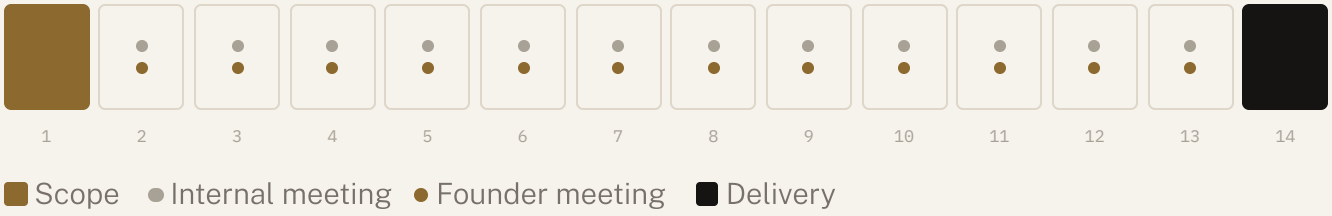
03 · HOW A PROJECT WORKS

How a project works

One team, one founder, one term, one written scope.

A project is one term of work by one team, for one founder or executive. Terms run in fall, spring and summer. The founder brings a real problem and about an hour a week. The company pays nothing and keeps all equity and intellectual property. Students earn academic credit.

A FALL OR SPRING TERM



Before	The studio matches the project with a team and a project advisor, and introduces them to the founder.
Week one	The founder and the project advisor write the scope: a week-by-week plan of what the team will deliver.
Every week	Two meetings. One internal, with the project advisor, on tasks and blockers. One with the founder, to review the work and adjust the scope.
End of term	The team delivers and hands over. The project advisor evaluates each student; the founder evaluates the project.
After	Students who delivered are invited back with more responsibility. An opportunity worth building may become a joint venture.

04 · THE TEAM

The team

About five students, an experienced project advisor and the founder.



Two college students, one of whom leads the team.

Three high school Builder Scholars, nominated by their schools.

Two roles are easy to confuse. The **team leader** is a college student who runs the team day to day. The **project advisor** is an experienced volunteer professional who coaches the team, keeps the scope honest and evaluates the work. Teams mix students from different schools on purpose, and studio staff oversee every team.

ROLES, TIME AND CREDIT

Team leader	College student	5 to 10 hrs a week	6 credit hours
Contributor	College student	4 to 8 hrs a week	3 credit hours
Builder Scholar	High school student	About 3 hrs a week	3 credit hours
Project advisor	Volunteer professional	Two meetings a week	—
Founder	The company	About 1 hr a week	—

05 · EXPECTATIONS

What each party commits to

The arrangement works when everyone does their part. This is what each is asked to do.

The founder

- Bring a real problem or opportunity that matters to the business.
- Write the scope with the project advisor in week one.
- Meet the team once a week and answer questions in between.
- Give honest feedback, including when the work falls short.
- Evaluate the project at the end of the term.

Students

- Give the hours the role requires, every week.
- Attend both weekly meetings, prepared.
- Deliver what the scope says, when it says.
- Keep the company's information confidential.
- Represent the company and the studio well.

The project advisor

- Run the weekly internal meeting and coach the team.
- Keep the scope current and the founder informed.
- Hold students to the standard the founder expects.
- Evaluate each student's work at the end of the term.

The studio

- Recruit and screen students and project advisors.
- Match each project with a team that can deliver it.
- Handle all academic paperwork and credit.
- Oversee every team and step in when a project is off track.

06 · THE WORK

The work

Every project falls into one or more of five kinds of work.

I	**Market research.** Customer interviews, market sizing and problem validation.
II	**Agentic engineering.** Websites, apps, internal tools and AI agents.
III	**Branding.** Names, logos, visual identity and messaging.
IV	**Marketing.** Photo, video, copywriting and paid advertising.
V	**Sales.** Lead lists, outreach and customer pipeline.



LIFETIME FITNESS · HEALTH & FITNESS CLUBS



OVERFLOW · GENEROSITY PLATFORM



BURLEBO · OUTDOOR APPAREL BRAND

07 · TERMS

Terms

What you give, and what you keep.

$0
Cost to the company

0%
Equity taken

~1 hr
Of your time each week

Ownership	Your company keeps all equity and intellectual property produced on the project.
Length	One term: fall, spring or summer. Projects can continue into another term with a new scope.
Team	About five students and a volunteer project advisor, overseen by studio staff.
Scope	Written with you in week one and reviewed with you every week.
Students	Earn academic credit. Paying them is your choice and not expected.
Joint ventures	Optional and separate. See Joint ventures, later in this booklet.

GOOD PROJECTS

Real, bounded and important to the business: a market study before a decision, an internal tool or AI agent, a brand or website, a campaign, a sales pipeline. The best projects are the ones a founder has wanted done for a year and never had the people for.

08 · OUTCOMES FOR FOUNDERS

Outcomes for founders

23
Companies served by student teams

78
Students placed on those teams

CASE · ADOPTION IS AN OPTION, 2026

A student ad competition, judged on cost per click

Student teams made TikTok ads for an adoption advocacy organization from May to July 2026. Ads were scored only on their performance in TikTok Ads Manager. Every winning ad was built on one made in the first round.

13.8M
Impressions

1.43M
Clicks to the website

10.39%
Click-through rate

$15,580
Total ad spend

54
Ads produced

$0.011
Cost per website visitor

COMPANIES SERVED

Lifetime Fitness
Overflow
Burlebo
The Care App
HeavyTech
Athletes Ocean
launch.kids
Minneoats
Baxo
Evergreen
TourCaddy
Velora
Regent Bank
Lecrae Media
Perm Cap
Tektones
Adoption.ls
Venture Forge
Commissioned
ShareYourStory
Today Matters
ServeSource
Turn

09 · FROM FOUNDERS

From founders

"Cole has been outstanding on our startup — smart, technically capable, coachable, hardworking, and a true team player. His contribution reflects not only strong technical skill, but the character, humility, and mission-minded leadership ACU is developing in its students."

Paul Kent Graeve
Founder & CEO, Today Matters

"I've spent years working in Big Tech in Silicon Valley with the world's most premiere talent. The profile of the ACU student is unique. The world has a lot of knowledge, but it needs more wisdom. ACU students are showcasing a rigorously intellectual foundation coupled with a moral, Christian fabric — a combo the world desperately needs more of. I wouldn't hesitate to bring an ACU student on."

John Kronlokken
Founder & CEO, Evergreen / Ex-Corporate Strategy, Google

"As an entrepreneur, I wish I had the college experience that ACU is creating. ACU provides students the opportunities they need to become excellent, and the students are delivering on that opportunity. Coming into the engagement, I thought it would be predominantly mentorship. I was wrong. The students delivered tangible value to our organization the whole way through. Movements like this will inspire the next generation of leaders to believe God is in all things, including our work."

Anthony Ruffner
Founder & CEO, Turn

10 · STUDENT STORIES

Student stories

Students don't need a business idea or a network. They need to show up and do excellent work.

Most 18-year-olds have poor business ideas and no network. The studio has both: opportunities found by experienced operators, and the founders, executives and investors behind them. A student raises their hand, is placed on a real project, and is judged on effort, attitude and the work itself. When they deliver, their network grows and opportunities follow. Here are three of them.

CE

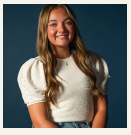
Cole Elzerman · *p. 14*

TEAM LEADER · COLLEGE STUDENT

PG

Preslee Gordon · *p. 15*

TEAM LEADER · UPPERCLASSMAN IN COLLEGE



Yakira Cardoso · *p. 16*

TEAM LEADER · COLLEGE STUDENT

STUDENT STORY · 01

Cole Elzerman

TEAM LEADER · COLLEGE STUDENT

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

TO CONFIRM · YEAR IN COLLEGE

CE

From waiting tables to leading a company spinning out of Life Time.

Gloo AI Hackathon	First place, 2025 and 2026
Current project	Life Time
Result	About $1.2 million a year saved
Next	Helping lead the spinout

Two summers ago, Cole was waiting tables. Since joining the studio he has won the Gloo AI Hackathon in Boulder, Colorado, two years in a row, and has worked on and led a series of projects for founders and executives.

One of the projects he leads now is for Life Time. His team built technology that is saving the company about $1.2 million a year in overhead. It is being spun out as its own company to commercialize, and Cole will help lead it.

STUDENT STORY · 02

Preslee Gordon

TEAM LEADER · UPPERCLASSMAN IN COLLEGE

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

TO CONFIRM · YEAR IN COLLEGE

PG

Leading two teams, and hired by the founders of one of the organizations she serves.

Projects	Commissioned, Best Buddies
Role	Team leader on both
Now	Part-time role with Commissioned's co-founders

Preslee has moved up through several projects and this fall leads two teams: one for Best Buddies, and one for Commissioned, a network of hundreds of Christian women entrepreneurs who gather each year to learn from one another.

Her Commissioned team helped put on this year's gathering. Working alongside the network's co-founders, she led the team well enough that they hired her as a paid, part-time member of their staff.

The event also introduced her to a great many women founders. She is learning to lead a team and deliver real value, and her network has grown faster than it could have any other way.

STUDENT STORY · 03

Yakira Cardoso

TEAM LEADER · COLLEGE STUDENT

TO CONFIRM · YEAR IN COLLEGE



An all-night pitch deck, a first-place finish and a seat on a founding team.

Project	Adoption Is An Option
Role	Team leader
Competition	First place, $12,000
Now	Founding team, Adoption Is An Option

Yakira joined the student team working with John Knox, a founder and philanthropist who was launching a nonprofit, Adoption Is An Option. When the students were given a chance to meet him, she stayed up all night building a pitch deck so she could bring him her own thinking about the organization he was starting.

He was impressed enough by the students, and by Yakira in particular, that he created a series of opportunities for them. One was a TikTok ad competition he funded, with $25,000 in cash prizes and ads judged only on how they performed. Yakira took first place and $12,000.

He then asked her to join the founding team launching Adoption Is An Option.

11 · JOINT VENTURES

Joint ventures

When a project finds something worth building, the studio builds it with you.

THE OPERATOR BRINGS

The opportunity, knowledge of the industry, and often the first customer.

THE STUDIO BRINGS

The team, Fellows working full time, and the work of building the company. The studio holds equity.

The studio expects to start about six companies a year this way. Current joint ventures include:

- **Unify.** Software for nonprofits: one connected platform in place of a stack of separate tools.
- **launch.kids.** A tool that teaches children to build software with AI.
- **Builder's Quotient.** An assessment of entrepreneurial ability, used to find students early.
- **Life Time spinout.** An AI data tool built for Life Time, now being spun out to commercialize, with Life Time as its first customer.

12 · THE NETWORK

The network



VALLEY CHRISTIAN SCHOOL



THE STONY BROOK SCHOOL



OAKS CHRISTIAN SCHOOL



SIERRA CANYON SCHOOL



SANTA FE CHRISTIAN SCHOOLS



GILBERT CHRISTIAN SCHOOLS

PARTNER HIGH SCHOOLS

Valley Christian School
The Stony Brook School
Oaks Christian School
Sierra Canyon School
Santa Fe Christian Schools
Gilbert Christian Schools
Greater Atlanta Christian School
Little Rock Christian Academy
Jupiter Christian School
Regent School of Austin
Southwest Christian High School
Cincinnati Hills Christian Academy
Linfield Christian School
Timothy Christian Schools
Silverdale Baptist Academy
Cuyahoga Valley Christian Academy

VENTURE FIRMS

Discipulus Ventures
Capital Factory
Overmatch
Sovereign's Capital
Live Oak Ventures
Wave Ventures
Eagle Venture Fund
Fireroad
11 Tribes
Worldview
Waterstone Impact Fund
Mission 3A
Keystone Capital
Stackhouse Ventures
Our Appologies
Sandbox.Fund

ORGANIZATIONS

Praxis
Faith Driven Entrepreneur
Gloo
Solving
Venture Forge
Christian Economic Forum
National Christian Foundation
Impact Foundation
The Signatry
Talanton
CESA
ACSI
SeedTree Group
Schools United
Classical Conversations
Classic Learning Test

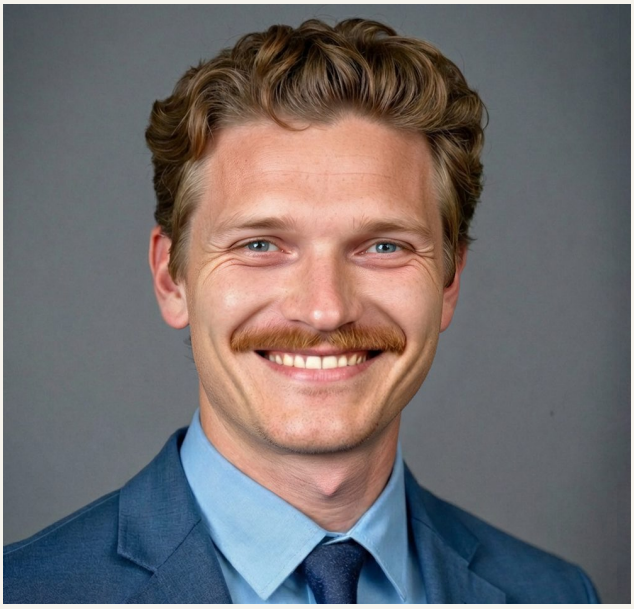
13 · LEADERSHIP

Leadership



Lars Ostervold

MANAGING PARTNER



Jake Oswald

MANAGING PARTNER

LEADERSHIP TEAM

Marshall Cunningham · Head of Operations

Tanner Dobbs · Head of Growth

Nate Steele · Head of Design

Taylore Hopkins · Head of Partnerships

Landen Enns · Head of Investor Relations

BOARD

Ben Peays · Board Chair

Connor Champion · Board Member

John Manning · Board Member

Ryan Wuerch · Board Member

Justin Forman · Board Member

Mark McClain · Board Member

Jake Thomsen · Board Member

14 · QUESTIONS

Questions

What does it cost?

Nothing. Companies never pay the studio. Students pay tuition for the course; the studio is funded by that and by the companies it owns.

Who owns the work?

You do. Your company keeps all equity and intellectual property produced on a project.

How much of my time does it take?

About an hour a week: a weekly meeting with the team and quick answers in between. More in the first week, when the scope is written.

What makes a good project?

Something real and bounded that matters to the business and has not been done because no one has had time: research, a build, a launch, a campaign, a pipeline.

What if the work is not good enough?

Tell the project advisor. Scope is reviewed every week. Teams that fall short are corrected, and the studio does not send a team it does not think can deliver.

Can I pay the students?

You may, but it is not expected and the studio does not arrange it. Students earn credit for the work.

15 · NEXT STEPS

Next steps

1

Describe the problem

Reply to the email this booklet came in with a few sentences on the problem or opportunity.

2

Scoping call

A 30-minute call with the studio to decide whether it is a fit and what a term could deliver.

3

Meet your team

The team is assigned before the term begins. Week one is spent writing the scope with you.

CONTACT

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